

The video is banal, a simple three-minute demonstration of the technology as it is meant to work, but it was targeted at a community of technology early adopters. Drew narrates the video personally, and as he's narrating, the viewer is watching his screen. As he describes the kinds of files he'd like to synchronize, the viewer can watch his mouse manipulate his computer. Of course, if you're paying attention, you start to notice that the files he's moving around are full of in-jokes and humorous references that were appreciated by this community of early adopters. Drew recounted, "It drove hundreds of thousands of people to the website. Our beta waiting list went from 5,000 people to 75,000 people literally overnight. It totally blew us away." Today, Dropbox is one of Silicon Valley's hottest companies, rumored to be worth more than \$1 billion.⁵

In this case, the video was the minimum viable product. The MVP validated Drew's leap-of-faith assumption that customers wanted the product he was developing not because they said so in a focus group or because of a hopeful analogy to another business, but because they actually signed up.

THE CONCIERGE MINIMUM VIABLE PRODUCT

Consider another kind of MVP technique: the concierge MVP. To understand how this technique works, meet Manuel Rosso, the CEO of an Austin, Texas-based startup called Food on the Table. Food on the Table creates weekly meal plans and grocery lists that are based on food you and your family enjoy, then hooks into your local grocery stores to find the best deals on the ingredients.

After you sign up for the site, you walk through a little setup in which you identify your main grocery store and check off the foods your family likes. Later, you can pick another nearby store if you want to compare prices. Next, you're presented with a list of items that are based on your preferences and asked: "What are you in the mood for this week?" Make your choices, select the number of meals you're ready to plan, and choose what you care about most